

DO NEGATIVE EXPRESSIVES IMPOSE CONTEXTUAL CONSTRAINTS IN A SECOND LANGUAGE?

A bilingual replication and extension

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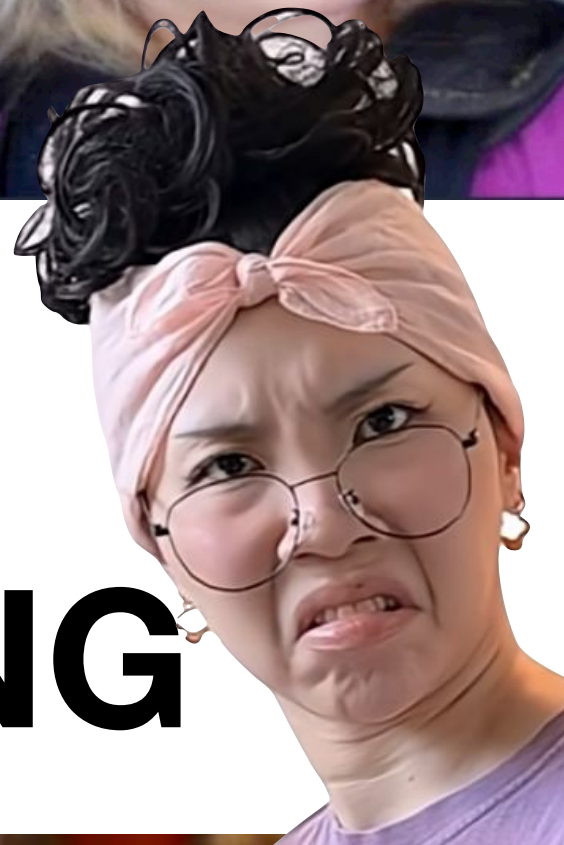


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**VALENCE
ASYMMETRIES**

THAT BASTARD
MARCO IS TALKING



THAT **BASTARD**
MARCO IS TALKING



Mixed expressives

McCready (2010), Gutzmann (2015)

Expressive
content





r/AITAFiltered · -3 j
Judgement_Bot_AITA App



AITA for needing the umbrella at a hotel pool?

r/AmltheAsshole · il y a 4 j

AITA for needing the umbrella at a hotel pool?

Pretty much this.

I needed the umbrella at a hotel pool (light sensitivity) and the lady next to me said she wanted the sun. I proceeded to tell her that I needed the shade and popped open the umbrella. She scoffed, and I said "you don't own the pool"-- which may have been much, but its true?

There was plenty of sunny space next to her, which her husband noticed and helped her scoot over so she could be in the sun.

AITA?

EDIT: Thanks everyone. I really needed the perspective because I really needed the shade, but I knew I could have handled that better. I accept the YTA determination.

484 upvotes · 210 commentaires



Judgement_Bot_AITA [AO](#) • il y a 3 j

The final verdict is: **Asshole**

Judgement	Total
YTA	60%
NTA	30%
INFO	4%
ESH	4%
NAH	2%

The top comment was made by [u/notrightmeowthx](#).



2



Récompenser



Partager

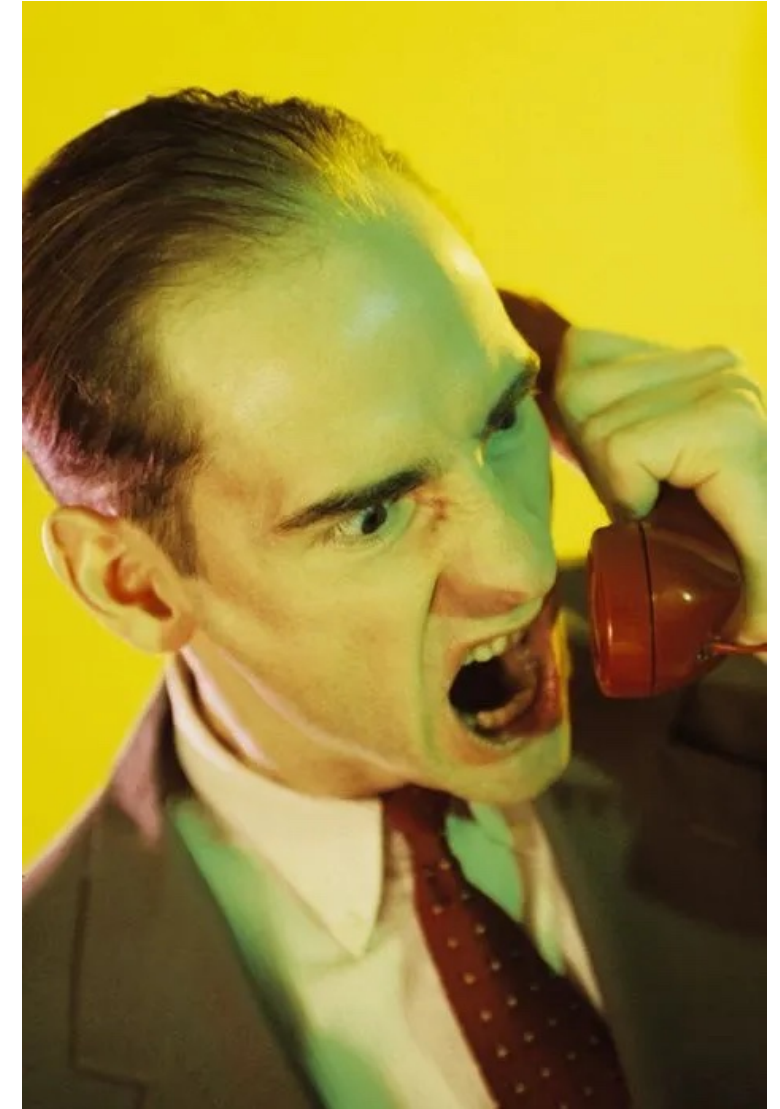


Mixed expressives

McCready (2010), Gutzmann (2015)

**Descriptive
content**

**Expressive
content**



Roadmap

- 1. Background: Expressive Content**
- 2. Background: Bilinguals**
- 3. Acceptability Task**
 1. Do we replicate Domaneschi et al. (2025)?
 2. Do we find the BAA effect?
- 4. Valence/Arousal Ratings: It. v. Eng**
- 5. Discussion / Work-in-progress**

What is expressive content?

Attitudinal and speaker-oriented

**That bastard Marco is
talking again...**



What is expressive content?

Attitudinal and speaker-oriented

That bastard Marco is
talking again...



S **believes** Marco
is a bad guy



What is expressive content?

Attitudinal and speaker-oriented

That bastard Marco is
talking again...



S **believes** Marco
is a bad guy

Marco **is** a
bad guy



What is expressive content?

- Conventional implicature, i.e., semantic content about the speaker's attitude (Potts 2005, 2006)
- Indexical presupposition about the speaker's attitude (Schlenker 2007)
- Projective lexical items but do not impose a strong contextual felicity constraint Tonhauser et al (2013)

Experimental evidence

No clear natural classes

CI content (Amaral et al. 2007; Harris & Potts 2009; Syrett & Koev 2015; Simons et al 2017; Koev 2018)

- Can be at-issue under the right conditions
- Not clearly different from presupposition

Projective content (Simons et al (2010); Tonhauser et al (2013); Simons et al (2017); Degen & Tonhauser (2021); Tonhauser et al (2018); Degen & Tonhauser (2022))

- Variable across triggers and contexts
- Sensitive to discourse structure/QUD
- Contextual beliefs modulate projection

Mixed Expressives: context licensed?

1. Ceporallo et al (2020)

SentenceType (2)

- **Referential** (that jerk V NP)
- **Predicative** (N is a jerk)

ContextCondition (2)

- **Neutral** (no info)
- **Satisfied** (Marco IS a jerk)

LexicalType (2)

- **Expressive** (jerk)
- **NegAdjective** (nasty)

5-pt likert

That jerk Marco is talking.



Marco is a jerk.

Mixed Expressives: context licensed?

1. Ceperallo et al (2020)

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LexicalType (2)

- **Expressive** (jerk)
- **NegAdjective** (nasty)

**Ref structures more
context sensitive**

**In Satisfied contexts
jerk $\approx$ nasty
In neutral contexts
jerk $<$ nasty**

Worse than Neg Adjs

5-pt likert

Mixed Expressives: speaker oriented?

2. Domaneschi et al (2025)

ContextCondition:

- **Agent-oriented** (S thinks badly of M)
- **Target-oriented** (Marco **IS** a jerk)
- **Neutral** (no information)

Lexical type:

- **Expressive** (e.g., jerk) (test)
- **Adjectives** (e.g., rude) (fillers)

Valence (pos. vs. neg., fillers only)

Marco is a jerk.



CONTEXT	CONDITIONS		CONTEXT 2	TARGET
Sara, Luca e Chiara are at the pub with some friends. Marco is drinking a coffee at another table.	AO	Luca dislikes Marco.	Luca says to Sara:	Marco is [a] jerk
	Int SBJ 1	Sara, Luca and Chiara dislike Marco ₁₆		
	Int SBJ 2	Sara, Luca, Chiara and others dislike Marco		
	TO	Marco is a fake and dishonest person.		
	NEU	//		

Mixed Expressives: speaker oriented?

2. Domaneschi et al (2025)

ContextCondition:

- **Agent-oriented** (S thinks badly of M)
- **Target-oriented** (Marco **IS** a jerk)
- **Neutral** (no information)

TO > AO

**in neutral contexts:
jerk < rude < kind**

Lexical type:

- **Expressive** (e.g., jerk) (test)
- **Adjectives** (e.g., rude) (fillers)

Valence (pos. vs. neg., fillers only)

**Exp2: hearers infer
MARCO DONE
WRONG**

CONTEXT	CONDITIONS		CONTEXT 2	TARGET
Sara, Luca e Chiara are at the pub with some friends. Marco is drinking a coffee at another table.	AO	Luca dislikes Marco.	Luca says to Sara:	Marco is [a] jerk
	Int SBJ 1	Sara, Luca and Chiara dislike Marco ₁₇		
	Int SBJ 2	Sara, Luca, Chiara and others dislike Marco		
	TO	Marco is a fake and dishonest person.		
	NEU	//		

Summary of *jerk* papers

Contextual licensing: We need to have evidence of Marco's assholery to use 'asshole' (unlike 'nasty')

Blameworthiness: Not so clearly just about (speaker's/people's) attitude, hearers infer Marco done wrong

Valence Asymmetry: Positive evaluations seem always good

What about L2 Speakers?

Do they show the same context sensitivity?

- Bilinguals may know the dictionary translation of an expressive without having identical pragmatic command over its use.
 - If L2 processing preserves semantic/pragmatic licensing, then the TO > NEU pattern should appear in both L1 and L2.
- If L2 processing attenuates affective force, then we should see L1-L2 differences.
 - E.G.: participants might show weaker differences between expressive and adjective items, or, weaker sensitivity to context
- AND - there is also an effect of valence (exploratory analyses; Domaneschi et al., 2025).

L2 Attenuated Affect Effect

*Does an expressive need contextual support because of its semantic/pragmatic licensing conditions, or because its **affective force** makes unsupported use feel less acceptable?*

- L2 words often have weaker affective force (Ferré et al., 2018; Imbault et al., 2021; Thoma, 2024)
 - Pronounced for Taboo words (Dewaele, 2004) and terms of endearment (Dewaele, 2008)
- Effects should be more pronounced when bilinguals have less experience in their L2 (measuring experience is complicated...)

Pragmatics in L2

Evidence of difficulty with pragmatics
and context-sensitive meaning

Taguchi 2019; Ren 2022; Wang & Wang 2023; McConachy 2019

YET potential reliance on context cues
to compensate lower linguistic
competence

Norman & Demain 2023; Bor & Prior 2022; Gollan et al 2002

Measuring Language Experience

Learning and Contexts of Use: Native vs. L2

Native Language:

- Family
- Play (childhood)
- School
- Internal monologue
- Social, emotional, moral learning

Sara, Gianluca and Chiara are attending a university lecture. A few places ahead they see Samuele sitting. Gianluca hates Samuele.

Gianluca says to Chiara:

"Samuele is an asshole."

L2:

- Classroom
- Formal work context
- Reading
- Paperwork



Language Experience & Proficiency

LEAP-Q assesses:

- Self-reported proficiency (reading, writing, listening, speaking)
- Age of acquisition
- Daily language use (% and contexts, e.g., reading)
- Immersion (country, school, family)
- Language learning contexts (e.g., friends, family, class, TV, etc.)
- Cultural identification
- Foreign accent
 - *Correlated variables*
 - *Inform affective engagement*



Questions

1. What is the nature of the expressive content in mixed expressive?

- Contextual constraint asymmetry for negative expressives (neutral < supporting; target-oriented > agent-oriented)?
- Lexical asymmetry: only for negative expressives

2. Does language nativeness (L1 vs. L2) modulate these effects?

- Sensitivity to affect? Nativeness*Valence
- Sensitivity to context? Nativeness*ContextCondition

Roadmap

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5. Discussion / Work-in-progress

Our Study

<i>Background</i>	Context Manipulation		<i>Target</i>
<i>Sara, Luca and Chiara are sitting at the bar with some friends. At another table Marco is drinking a coffee</i>	(1) Agent-oriented	Luca hates Marco (Luca odia Marco)	<i>Luca says to Sara (Luca dice a Sara), Marco is an asshole (Marco e uno stronzo)</i> jerk -> asshole
	(2) Target-oriented	Marco is bad person (Marco è una cattiva persona)	
	(3) Neutral	//	
<i>Note.</i> Conditions are counterbalanced, such that participants see at least two vignettes for each condition across the 9 target vignettes.			

+positive pejorative/expressive (sweetheart)!

Design

Within-Subjects

- **LexicalType** (pej,adj)
- **Valence** (neg,pos) +positive expressives!
- **ContextCondition** (TO,AO,NEU)

12 unique test trial types

36 total trials

counterbalanced in a Latin-Square design

24 filler vignettes

Between-subjects:

- **Nativeness** (ItalianL1, EnglishL1)

Procedure

- Acceptability judgment task with stimuli from Domaneschi et al. (2025) (minimally modified)
- LEAP-Q bilingual demographics
- + Valence/Arousal rating task

Participants ($n = 515$)

- Italian L1-English L2 Bilinguals (Study 1, $n=300$)
 - **Living in Italy** ✓
 - Living in English-speaking countries ($n \approx 190$ 😭)
- English L1-Italian L2 Bilinguals (Study 2, $n=215$)
 - **Living in English-speaking countries** ✓
 - Living in Italy ($n \approx 22$ 😭)

133 after
exclusions

TO: Giovanni is a bad person

AO: Luca hates Giovanni



progress

Pier, Gianluca and Luisa and other friends are jogging. A few meters away they notice Giovanni.

ContextCondition

Luisa says to Pier:

"Giovanni is an asshole."

How acceptable do you consider the statement in red?

completely
unacceptable



completely
acceptable

Next



progress

Laura, Stefano and Valentina are standing at the entrance of a cinema. In the queue they see Paolo buying tickets. Laura really likes Paolo.

LexicalType

Pejorative
Adjective

Laura says to Stefano:

"Paolo is a sweetheart."

Valence

Positive
Negative

How acceptable do you consider the statement in red?

completely
unacceptable



completely
acceptable

Next

Analyses

Q1a-c: (replication) Do expressive need contextual Licensing? Does Valence explain responses better than Lexical Type? Are there any Valence Asymmetries?

M1: Acceptability $\sim$ LexicalType*ContextCondition

M2: Acceptability $\sim$ LexicalType*ContextCondition*Valence

Q2: Bilingual differences?

M3: M2: Acceptability $\sim$... * **Nativeness**

Likelihood ratio tests for model comparison

Study 1

Analysis

```
M1 <- lmer(SliderResponse ~ ContextCondition*LexicalType +
(1+ContextCondition|Name) + (1+ContextCondition|Participant), data = d)
```

Fixed effects:

	Estimate	Std. Error	df	t value	Pr(> t)	
(Intercept)	63.062	1.629	165.054	38.704	< 2e-16	***
ContextConditionNEU	-20.075	2.139	102.601	-9.387	1.76e-15	***
ContextConditionT0	6.728	1.145	99.877	5.877	5.53e-08	***
LexicalTypepej	12.314	2.586	105.022	4.762	6.18e-06	***
ContextConditionNEU:LexicalTypepej	-7.027	2.814	68.336	-2.497	0.0149	*
ContextConditionT0:LexicalTypepej	-1.577	1.585	71.341	-0.995	0.3230	

```
M2 <- lmer(SliderResponse ~ ContextCondition*LexicalType*Valence +
(1+ContextCondition|Name) + (1+ContextCondition|Participant), data = d)
```

Fixed effects:

	Estimate	Std. Error	df	t value	Pr(> t)	
(Intercept)	58.725	1.848	150.067	31.776	< 2e-16	***
ContextConditionNEU	-28.643	1.760	105.751	-16.275	< 2e-16	***
ContextConditionT0	7.478	1.385	74.443	5.398	7.72e-07	***
LexicalTypepej	5.942	3.018	108.733	1.969	0.051535	.
Valencepos	8.808	2.411	110.489	3.653	0.000398	***
ContextConditionNEU:LexicalTypepej	-7.554	2.431	48.907	-3.107	0.003142	**
ContextConditionT0:LexicalTypepej	2.543	1.936	56.305	1.314	0.194303	
ContextConditionNEU:Valencepos	21.394	2.161	62.045	9.898	2.20e-14	***
ContextConditionT0:Valencepos	-1.937	1.882	63.699	-1.029	0.307291	
LexicalTypepej:Valencepos	12.599	4.269	108.728	2.952	0.003873	**
ContextConditionNEU:LexicalTypepej:Valencepos	-3.420	3.438	48.907	-0.995	0.324810	
ContextConditionT0:LexicalTypepej:Valencepos	-7.782	2.738	56.306	-2.843	0.006224	**

Analysis

M3: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*Valence*Nativeness

Fixed effects:

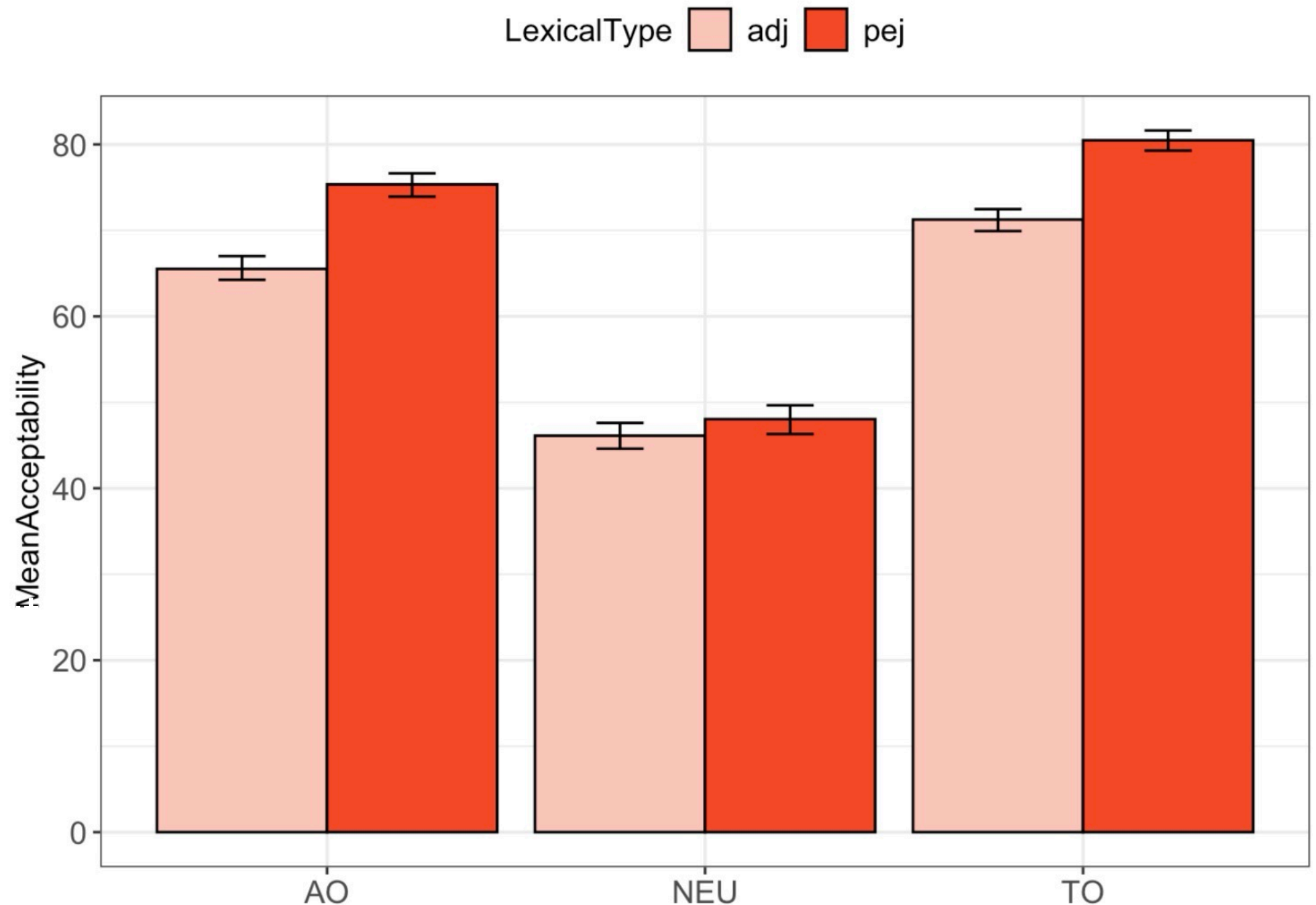
	Estimate	Std. Error	df	t value	Pr(> t)	
(Intercept)	52.1869	3.1174	94.7363	16.741	< 2e-16	***
LexicalTypepej	-4.1874	3.9195	62.6876	-1.068	0.28945	
ContextConditionNEU	-19.1598	3.0057	170.3245	-6.374	1.66e-09	***
ContextConditionT0	8.0133	2.3040	867.1933	3.478	0.00053	***
Valencepos	13.0038	3.7918	55.2226	3.429	0.00115	**
NativenessL2	-3.9298	4.6932	117.6251	-0.837	0.40410	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionNEU	-2.9003	3.3943	91.4092	-0.854	0.39508	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionT0	3.5580	2.9648	2175.4456	1.200	0.23023	
LexicalTypepej:Valencepos	13.9757	5.3624	55.2226	2.606	0.01175	*
ContextConditionNEU:Valencepos	15.6020	3.3940	91.4853	4.597	1.37e-05	***
ContextConditionT0:Valencepos	-3.9186	2.9638	2179.7396	-1.322	0.18626	
LexicalTypepej:NativenessL2	0.9191	5.7979	75.1908	0.159	0.87447	
ContextConditionNEU:NativenessL2	-0.4726	4.7186	222.6121	-0.100	0.92030	
ContextConditionT0:NativenessL2	4.3014	3.6531	907.7942	1.177	0.23933	
Valencepos:NativenessL2	10.5463	5.5756	64.8750	1.892	0.06302	.
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionNEU:Valencepos	-1.8980	4.7998	91.4853	-0.395	0.69345	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionT0:Valencepos	-4.2923	4.1914	2179.7396	-1.024	0.30592	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionNEU:NativenessL2	-2.1437	5.2683	132.2655	-0.407	0.68474	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionT0:NativenessL2	1.6171	4.7048	2771.1379	0.344	0.73108	
LexicalTypepej:Valencepos:NativenessL2	3.0463	7.8851	64.8750	0.386	0.70051	
ContextConditionNEU:Valencepos:NativenessL2	-3.0775	5.2680	132.3384	-0.584	0.56009	
ContextConditionT0:Valencepos:NativenessL2	-5.9588	4.7041	2772.0534	-1.267	0.20535	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionNEU:Valencepos:NativenessL2	2.0641	7.4501	132.3384	0.277	0.78217	
LexicalTypepej:ContextConditionT0:Valencepos:NativenessL2	-2.8120	6.6526	2772.0534	-0.423	0.67255	

Replication?

Italian L1 English L2

✓✓ {TO, AO} > NEU
TO > AO

Main effect of
ContextCondition



M1: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition

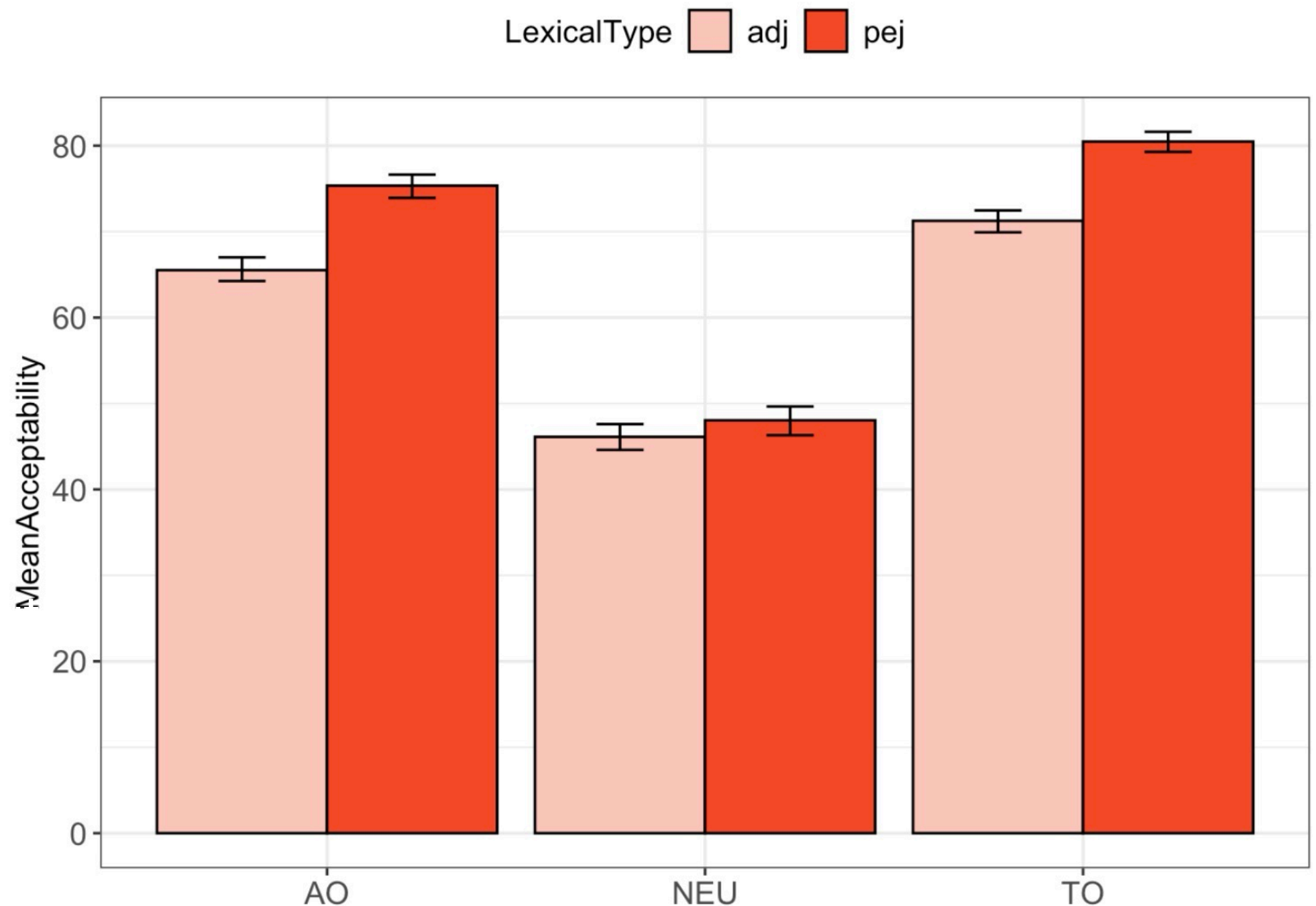
Replication?

Italian L1 English L2

X Pej more acceptable!

Main effect of
ContextCondition

Main effect of
LexicalType



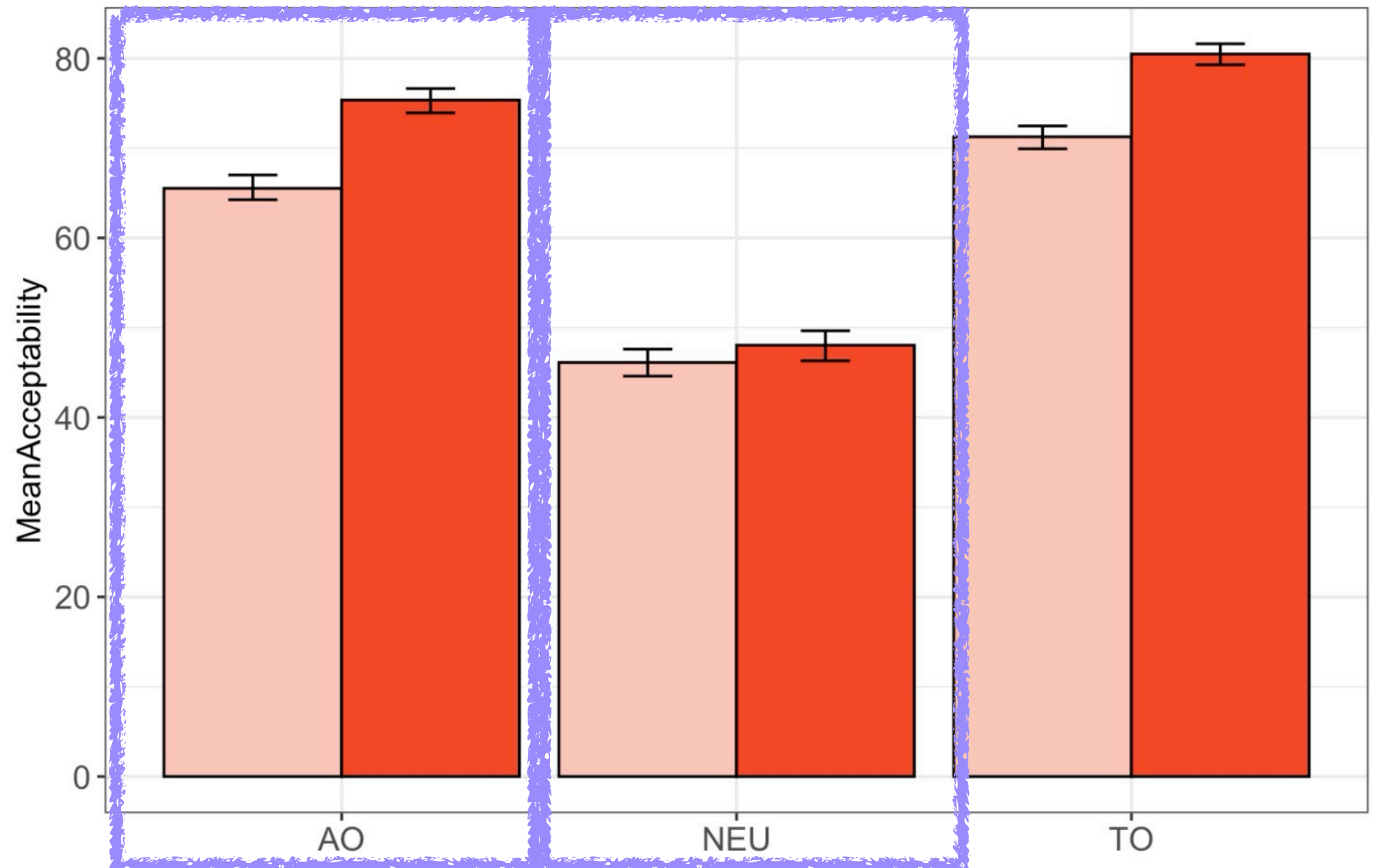
M1: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition

Replication?

Italian L1 English L2

Pej > Adj effect comes out really in the **AO**

LexicalType adj pej



Main effect of ContextCondition

Main effect of LexicalType

Slight Interaction with LexicalType

M1: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition

RQ1: Context Effects

Replicated Domaneschi et al. (2025)

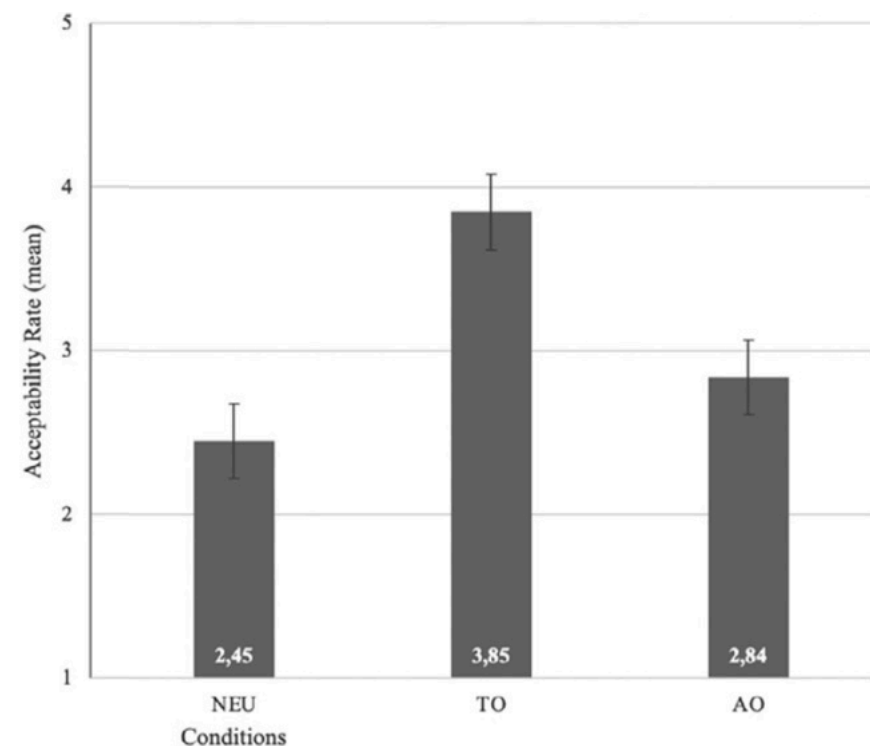
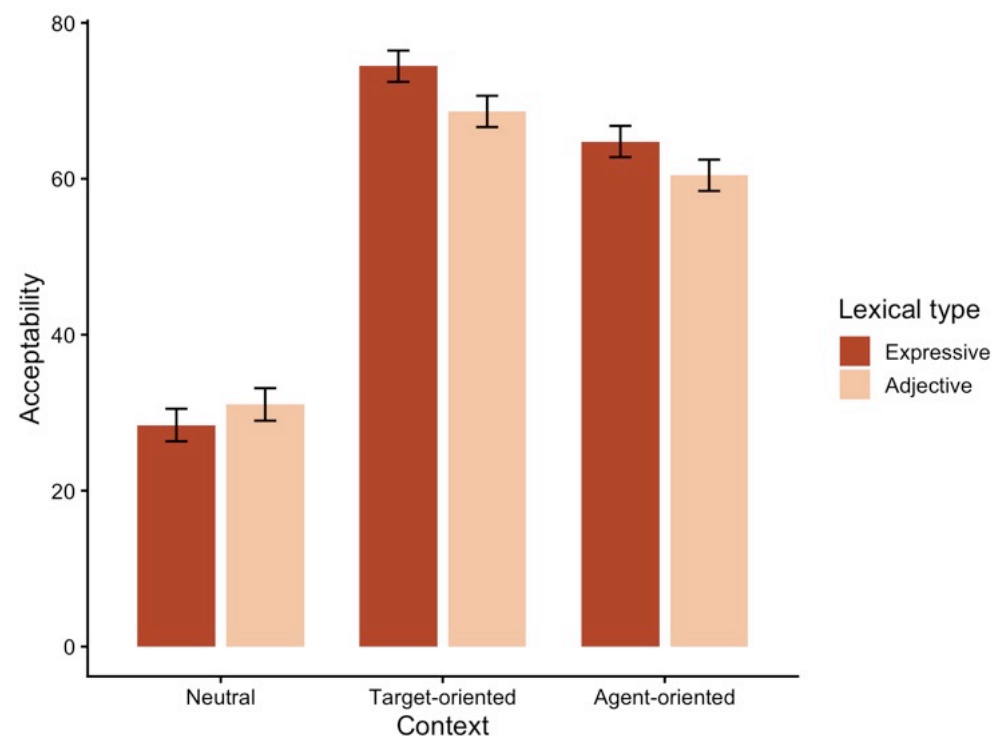
Model: acceptability ~ context × lexical type × Nativeness

Context effect:

- Differed by lexical type: stronger for expressives
- But not by language

Negative expressives show:

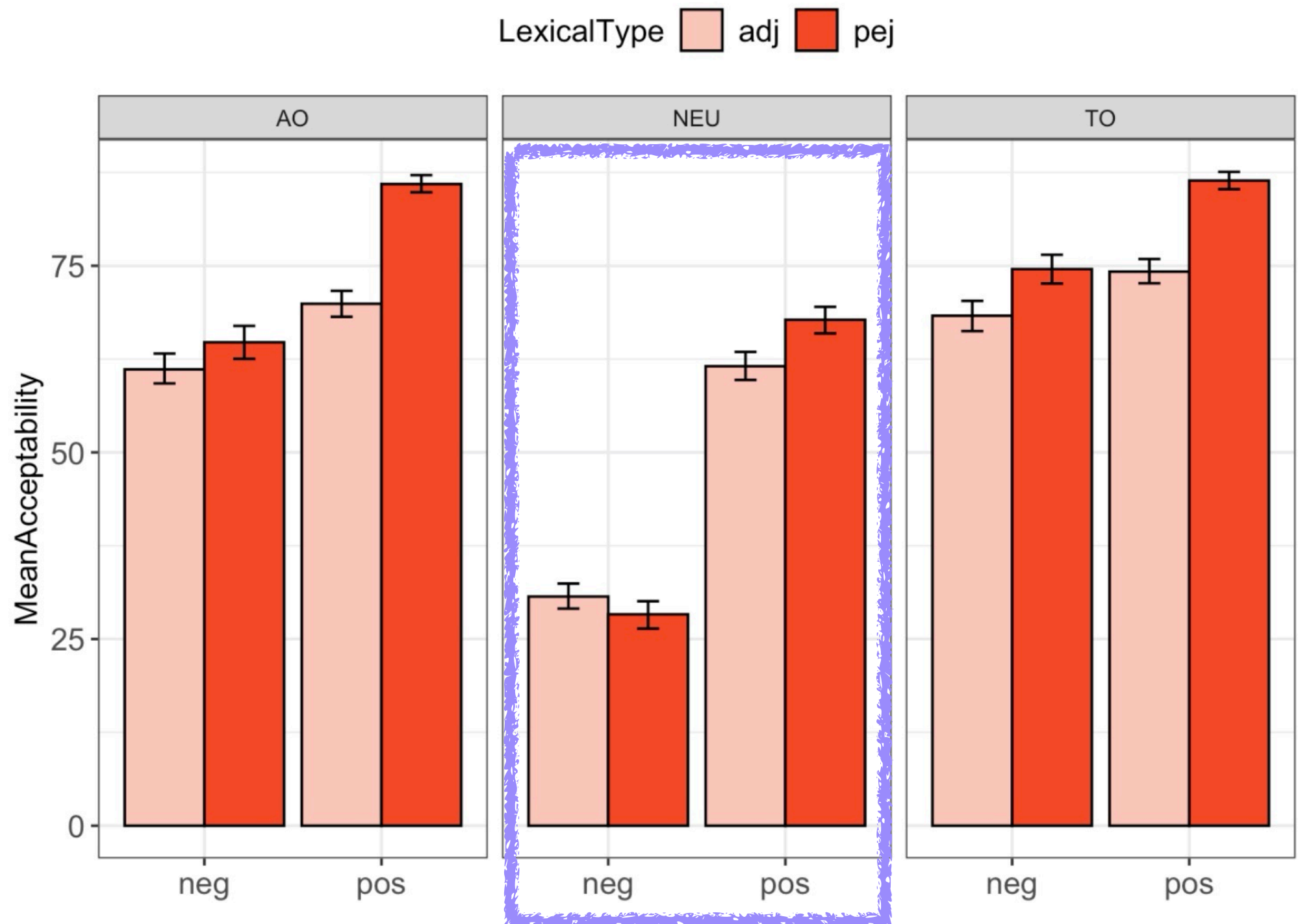
- Lower acceptability in neutral contexts than supporting contexts (TO & AO)
- Higher acceptability in target-oriented than agent-oriented contexts



Valence Asymmetry?

Italian L1 English L2

**Biggest
effect of
valence in
is the
neutral
condition**



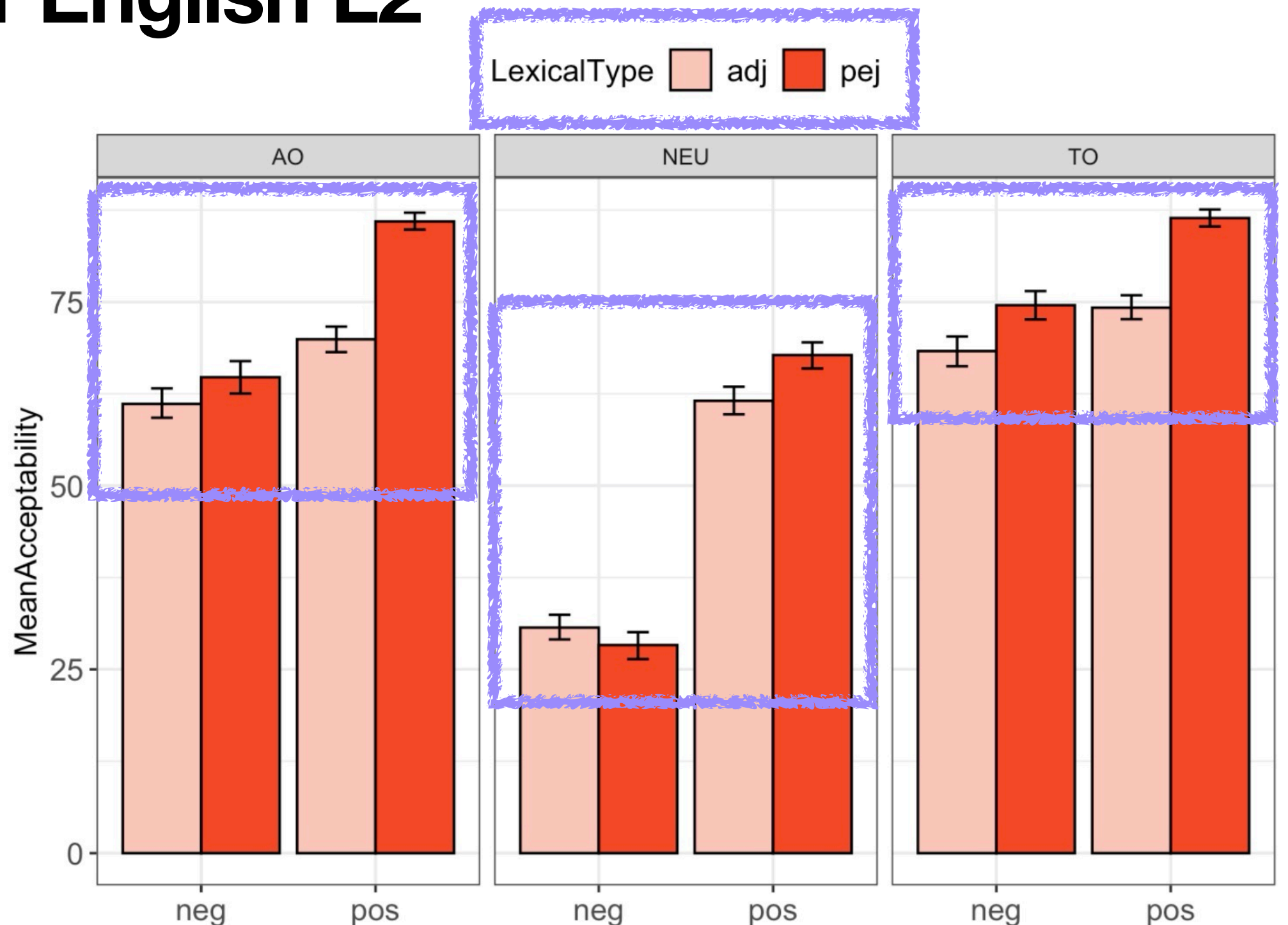
M2: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*cValence

Valence Asymmetry?

Italian L1 English L2

Valence differs
for pej and adj

**sweetheart/
teosoro
DRIVES
ACCEPTABLE**



M2: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*cValence

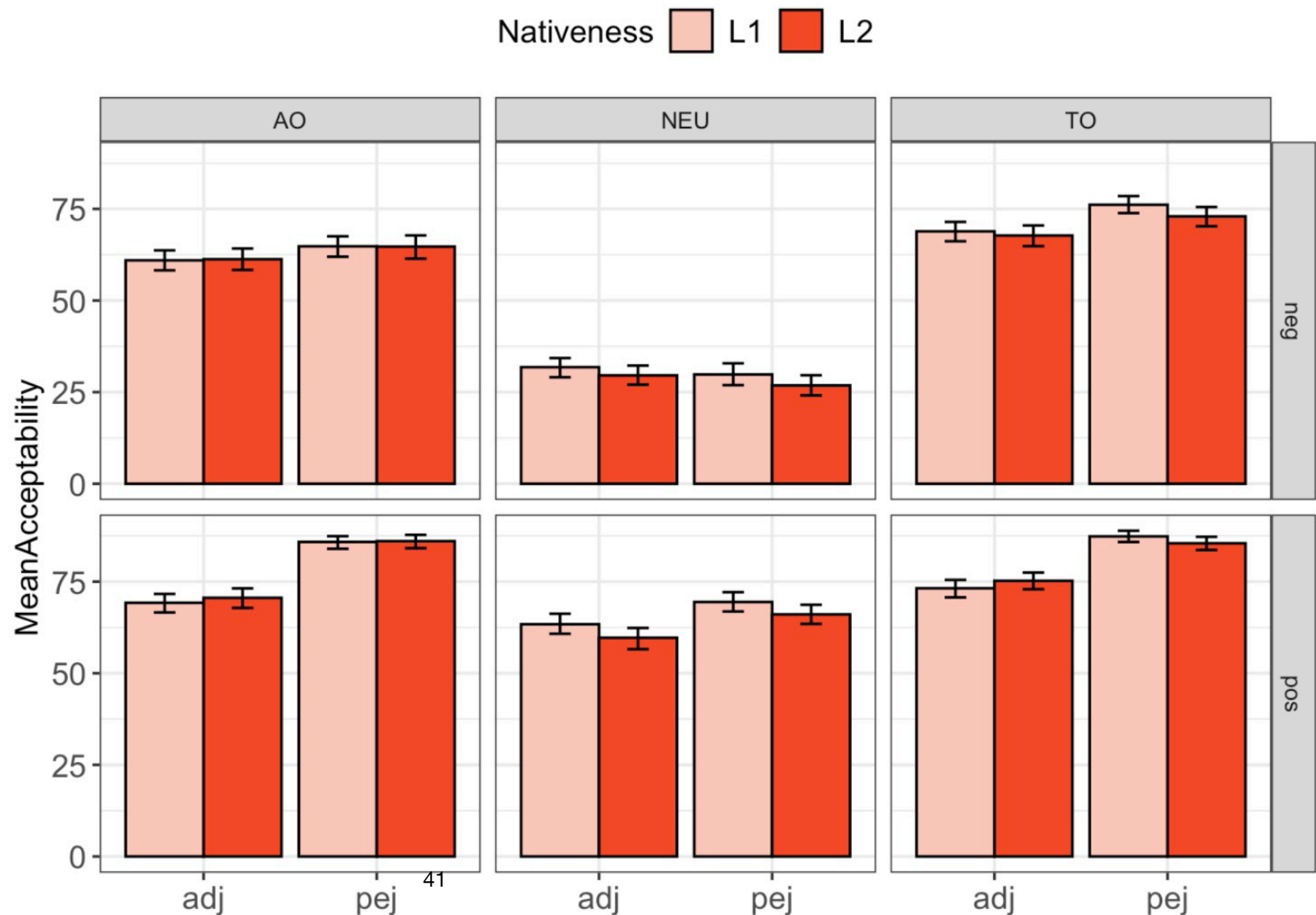
Bilingual Effects in Study 1?

Italian L1 English L2

No 3 or 4-way interactions

X Nativeness*CC

**Valence*Native
ness trending
but not sig.**



M3: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*Valence*Native

Study 1

S2: English L1 Italian L2

We can use the Leap Q!

58 participants excluded for no Italian knowledge (prolific error 🤔😭👁️👁️)

Further exclusions based on proficiency:

- Reading



S2: English L1 Italian L2

We can use the Leap Q!

58 participants excluded for
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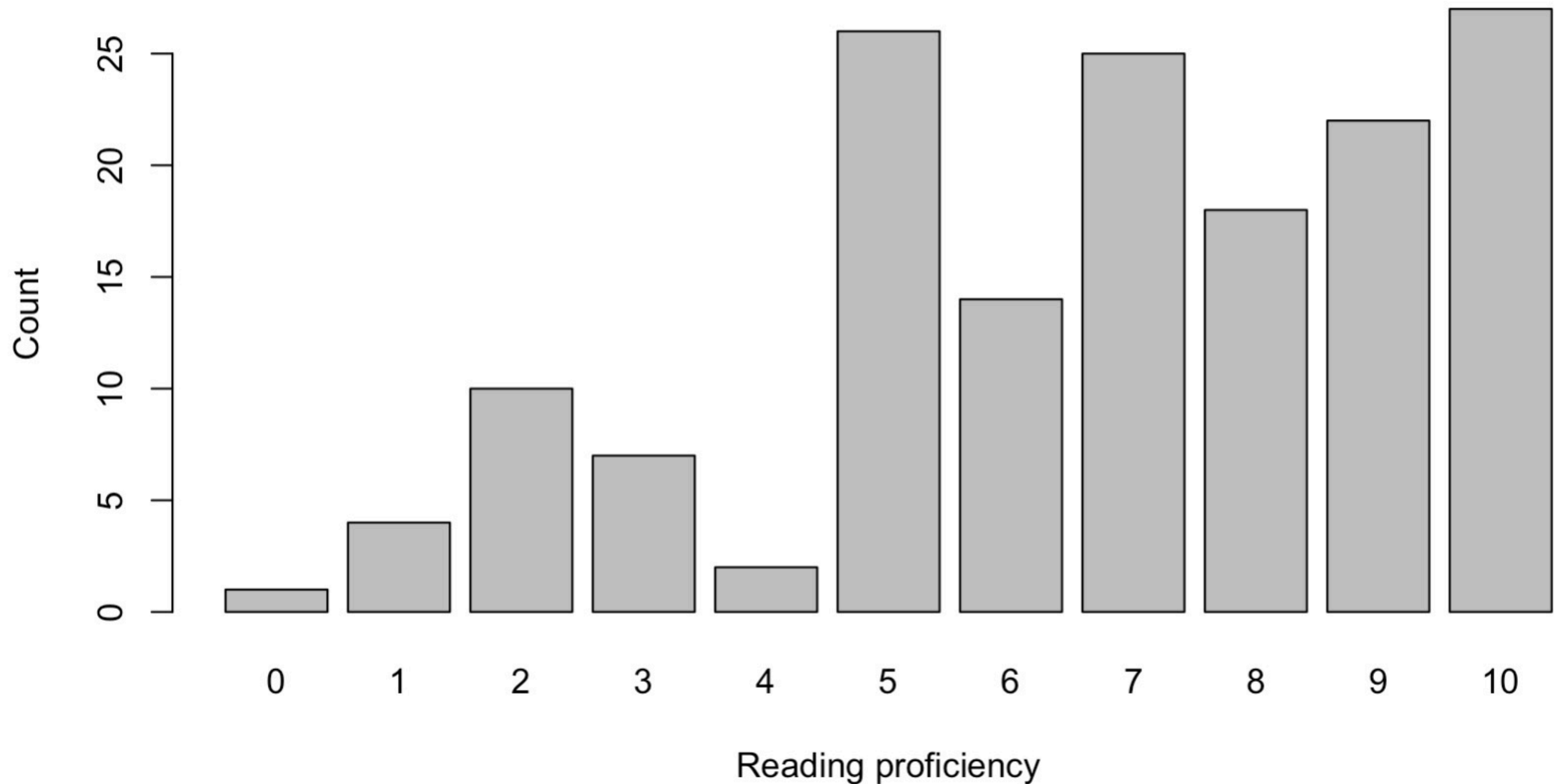
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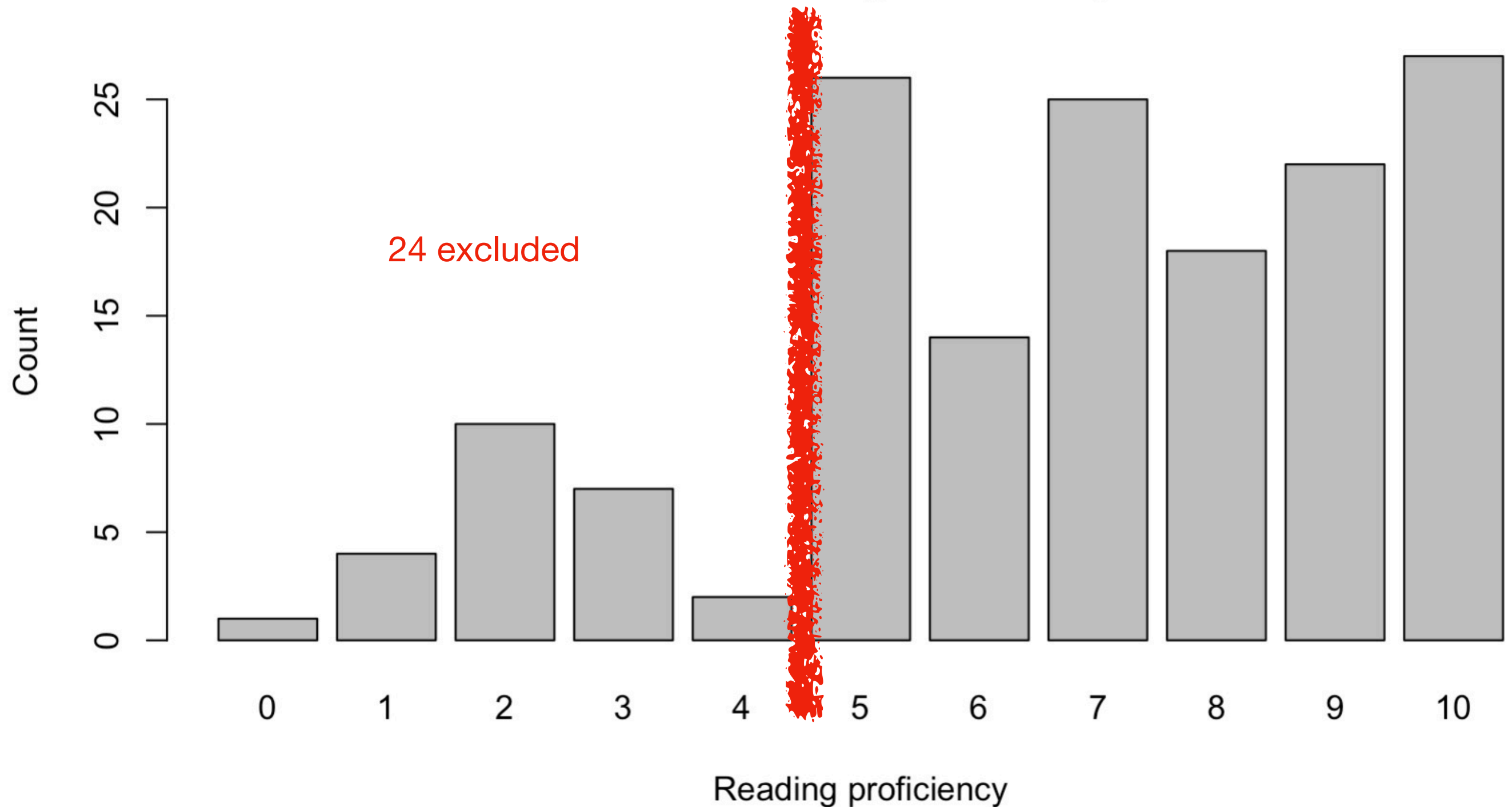
Reading Proficiency

Italian Reading Proficiency



Reading Proficiency

Italian Reading Proficiency

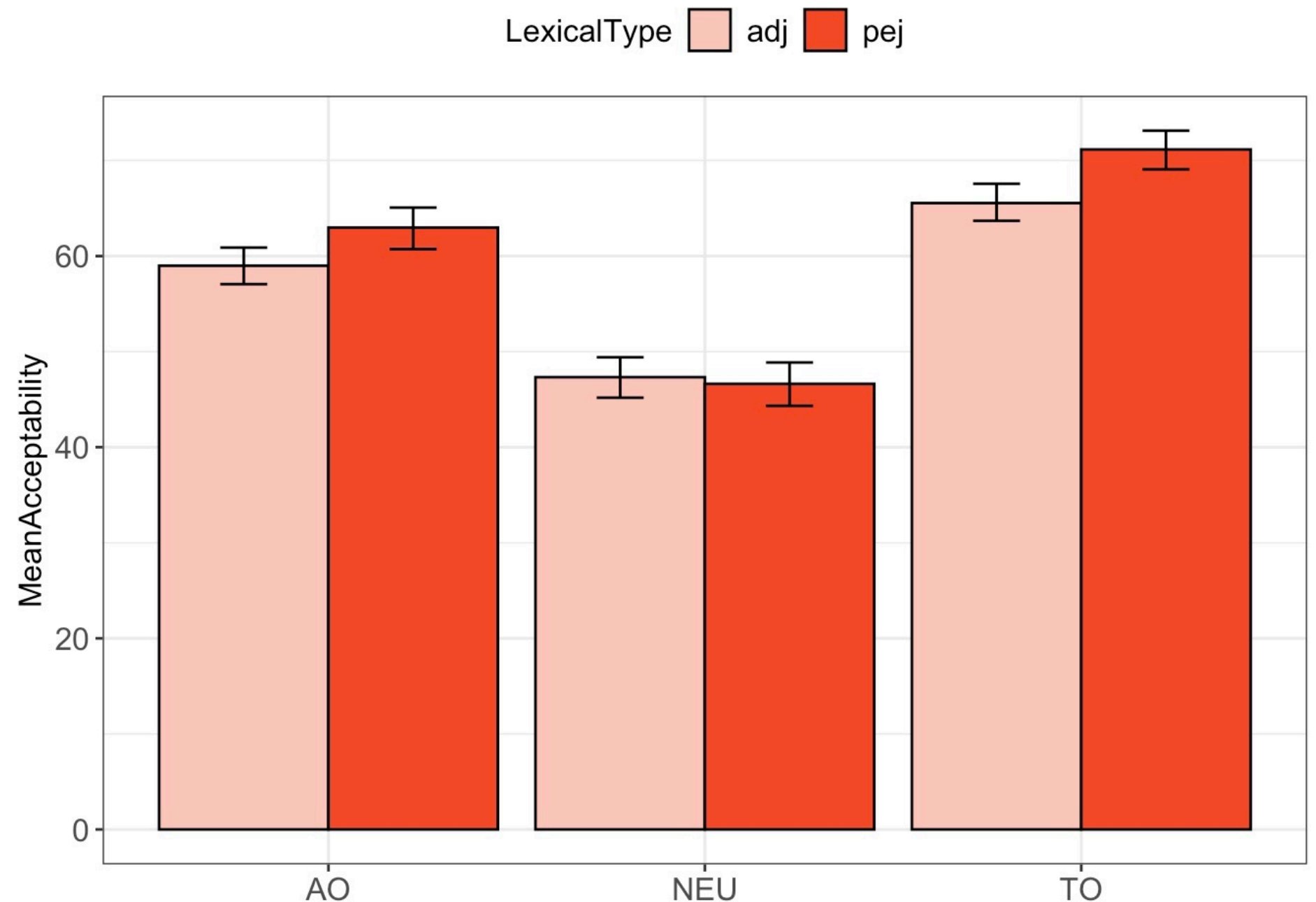


Replication?

English L1 Italian L2

✓✓ {TO, AO} > NEU
TO > AO

Man effect of
ContextCondion



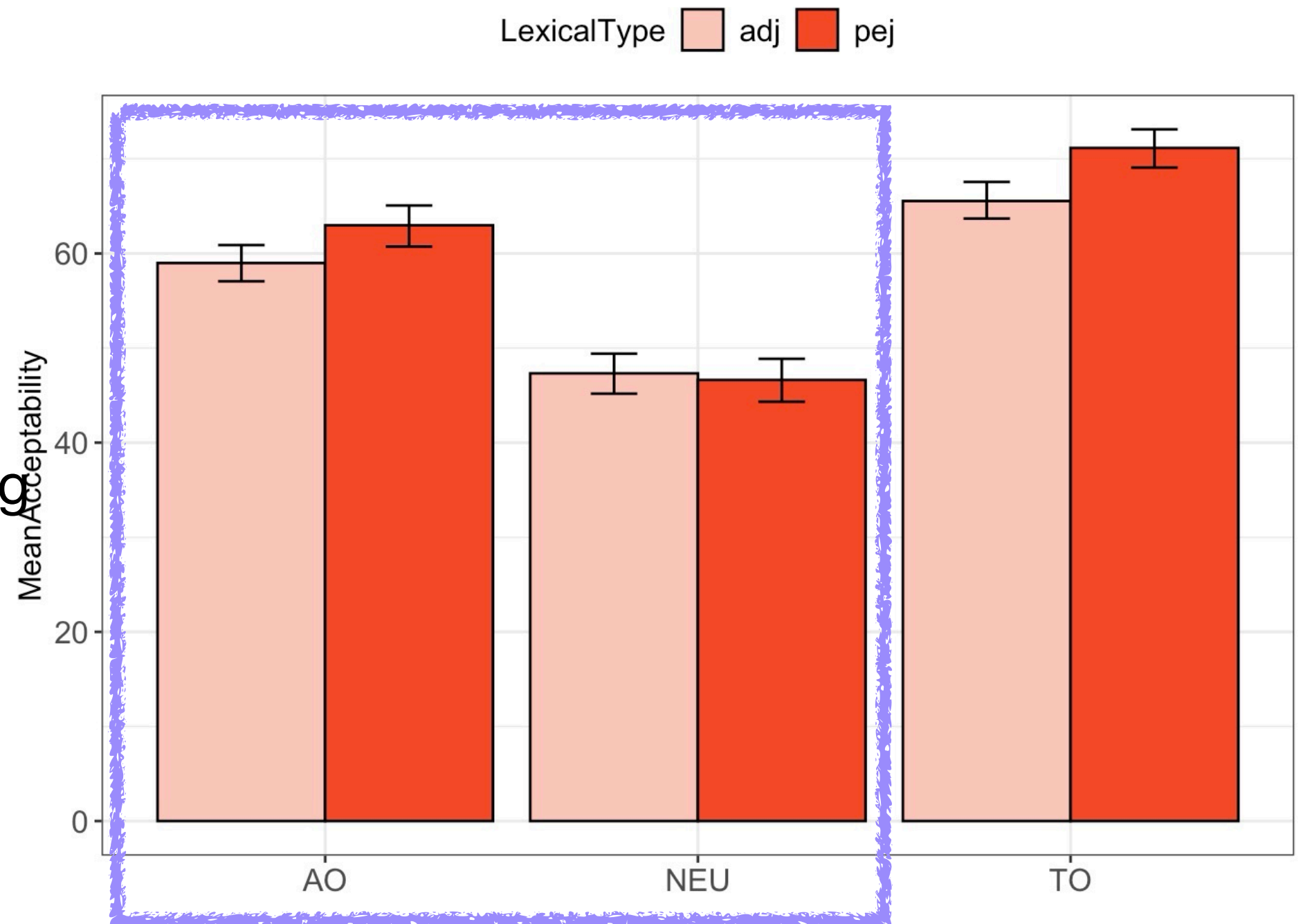
M1: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition

Replication?

English L1 Italian L2

Main effect of
ContextCondition

Interaction with
LexicalType trending
but **not significant**
unlike S1)



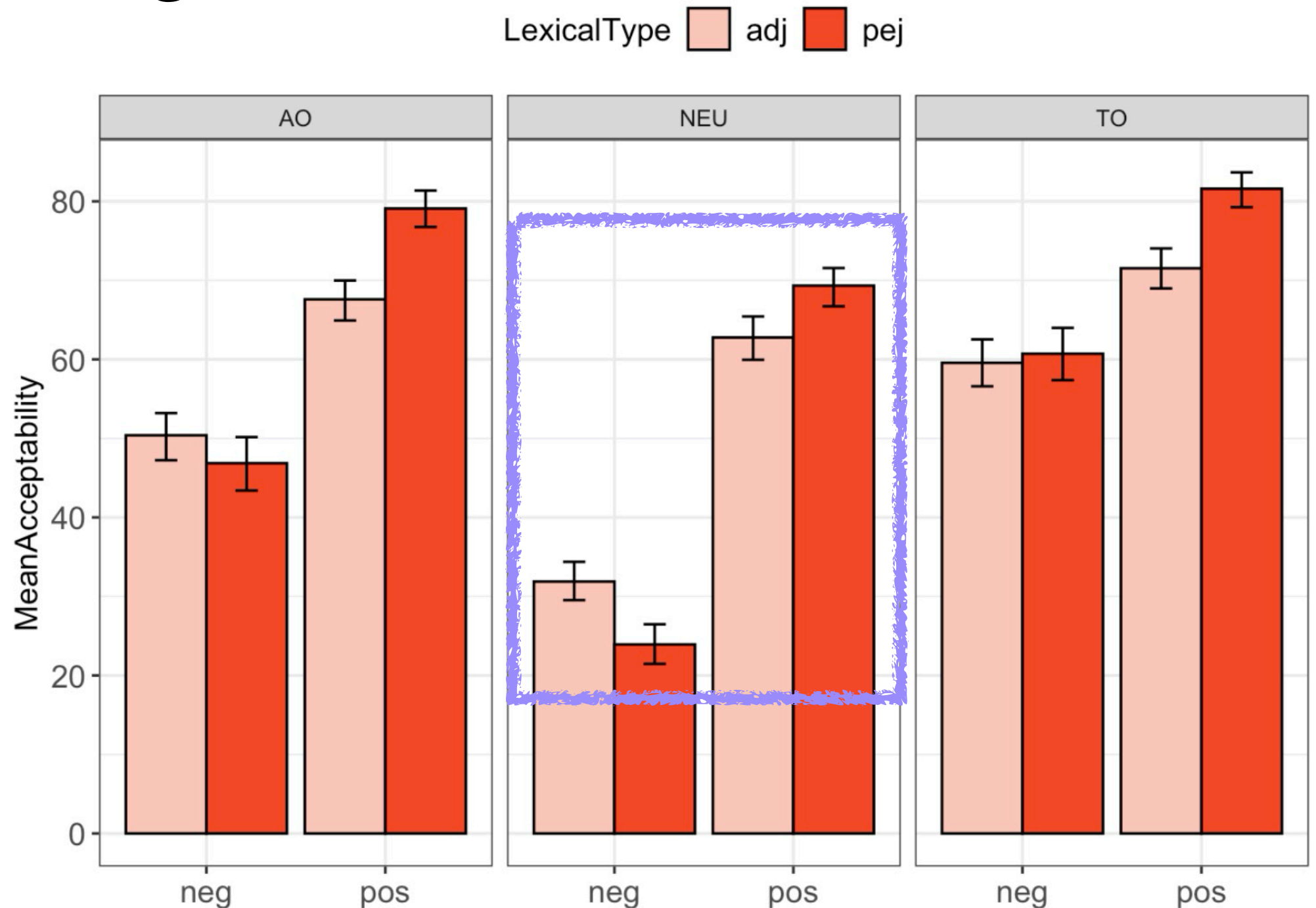
M1: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition

Valence Asymmetry?

Italian L1 English L2

Similar, but
cleaner result:

Biggest
effect of
valence in
is the
neutral
condition



M2: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*cValence

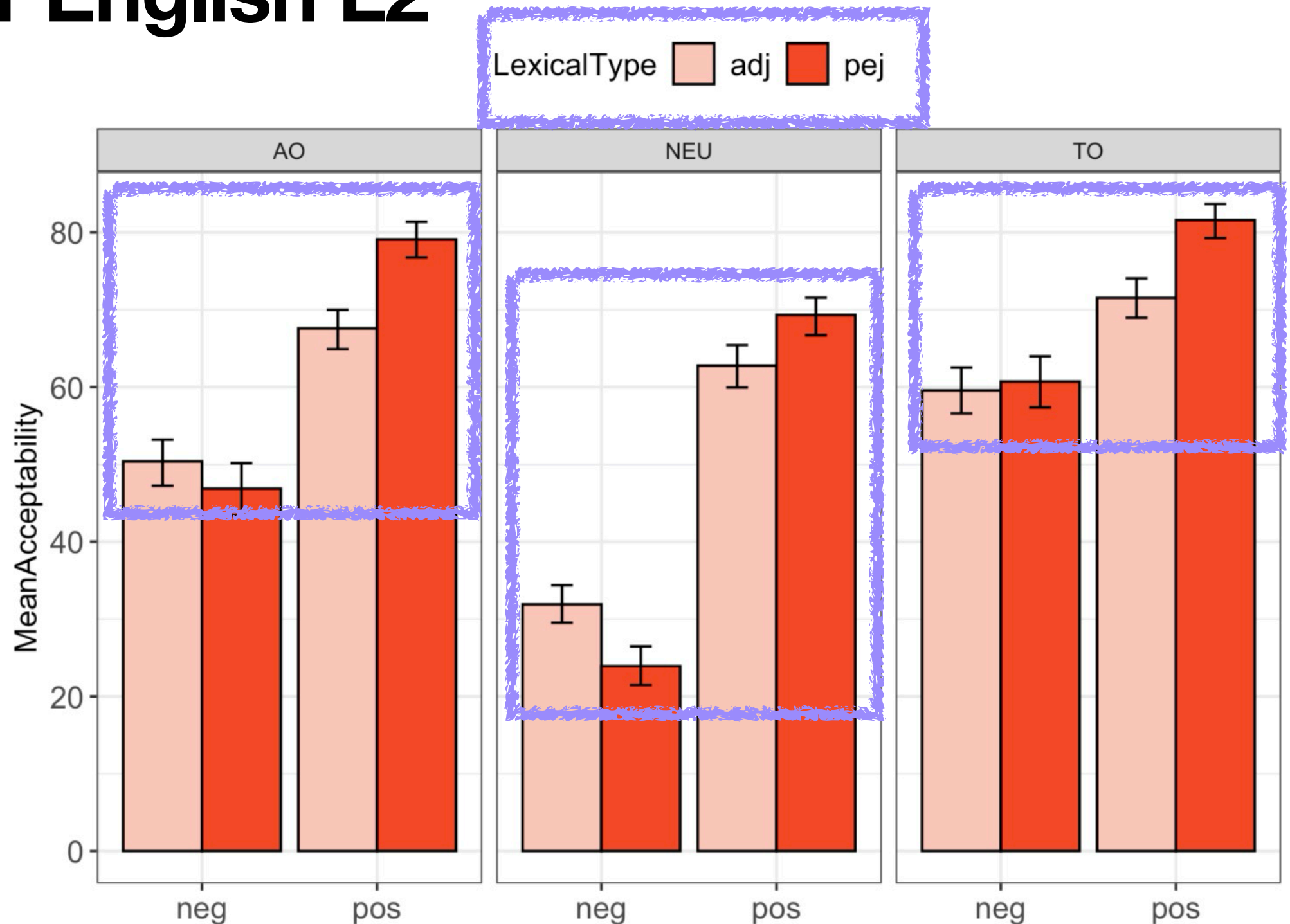
Valence Asymmetry?

Italian L1 English L2

Similar, but
cleaner result:

Valence differs
for pej and adj

**sweetheart/
tesoro
DRIVES
ACCEPTABLE**



M2: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*cValence

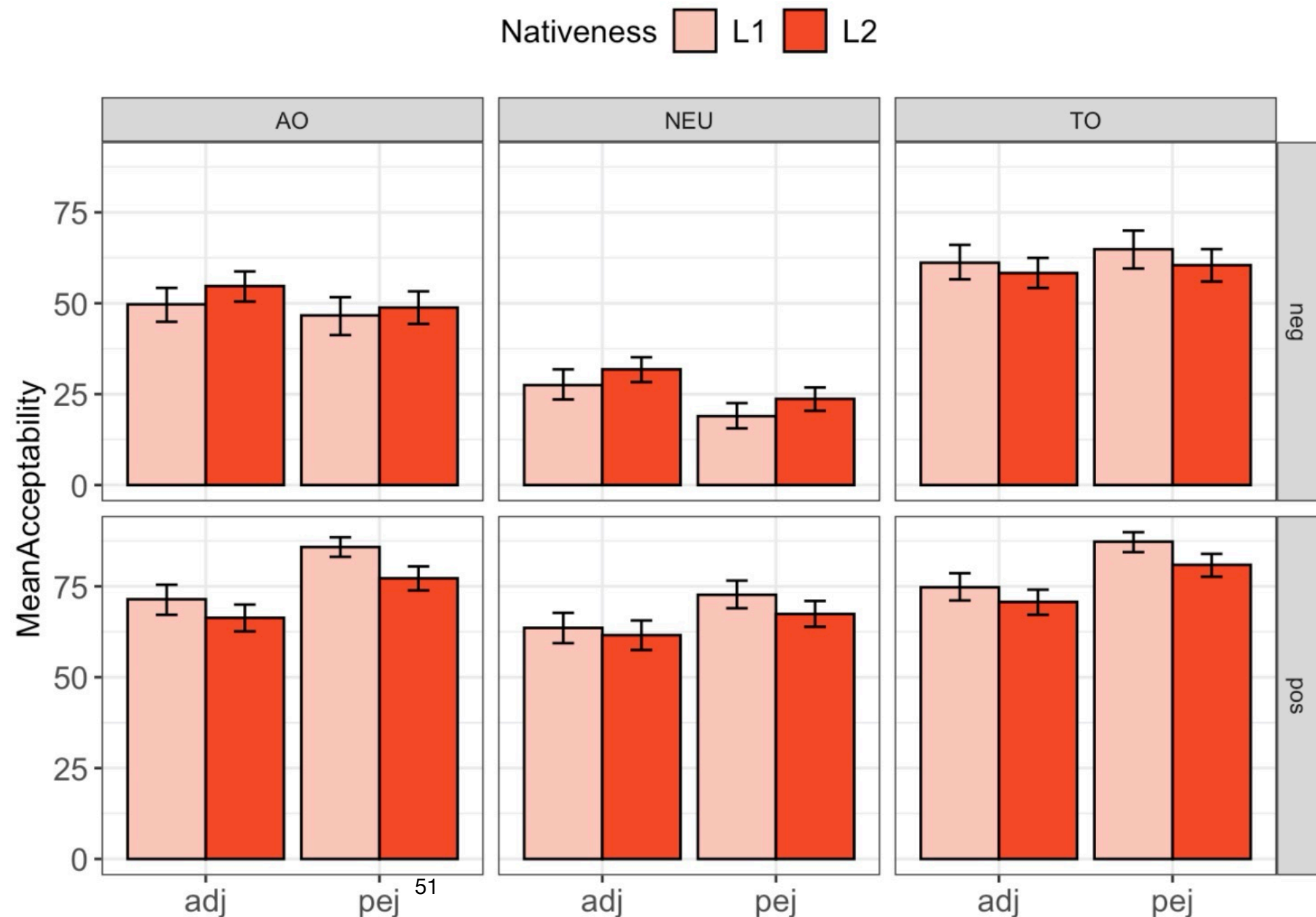
Bilingual Effects in Study 2?

English L1 Italian L2

No 3 or 4-way interactions

✗ Nativeness*CC

✓ Valence*
Nativeness



M3: Acceptability ~ LexicalType*ContextCondition*Valence*Nativeness

Rating Task

Instructions from Warriner et al. 2013

progress

rude

Valence

unhappy 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 happy
○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

calm 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 excited
○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Arousal

☐ I don't understand this word.

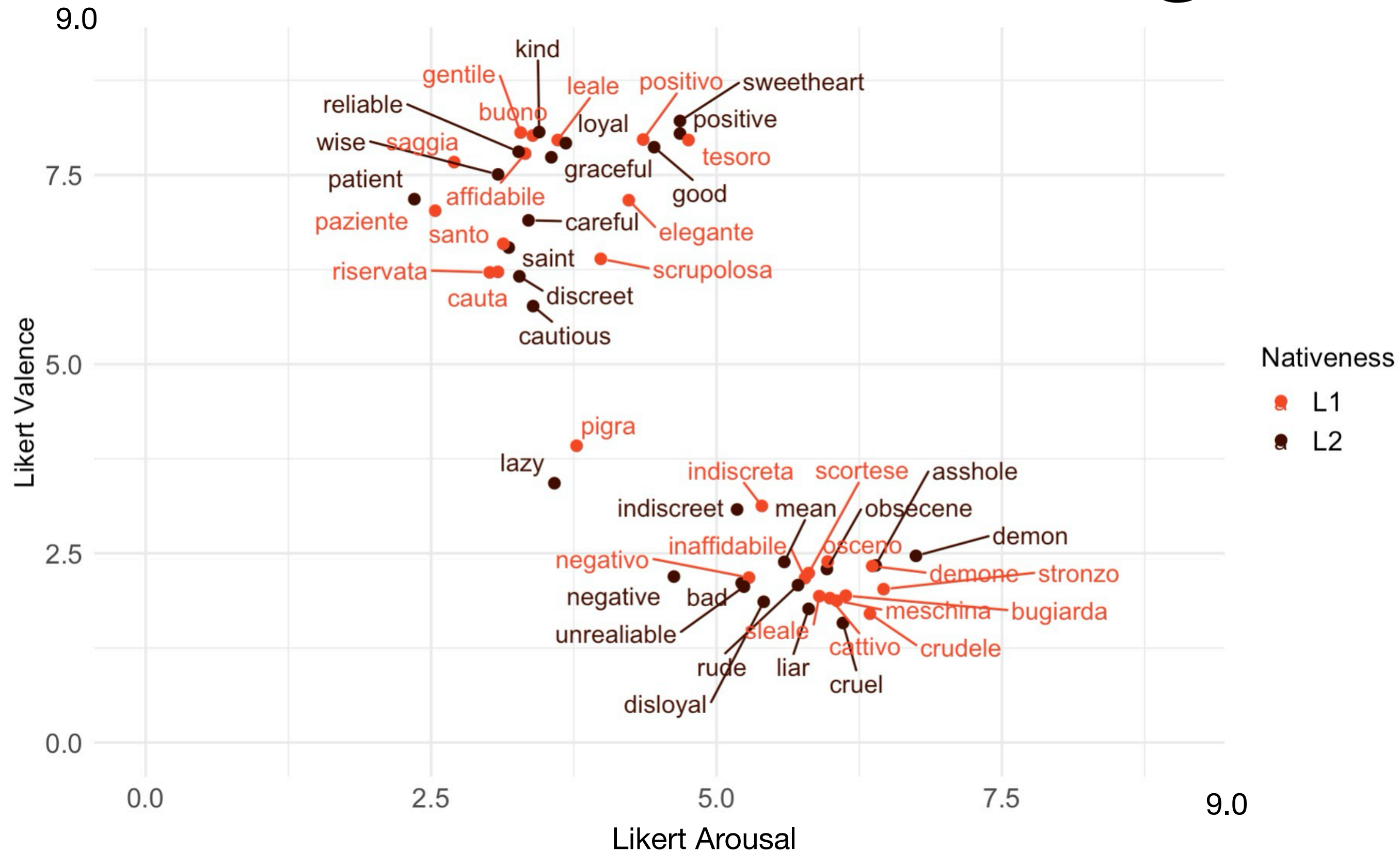
Next

Italian-English word pairs

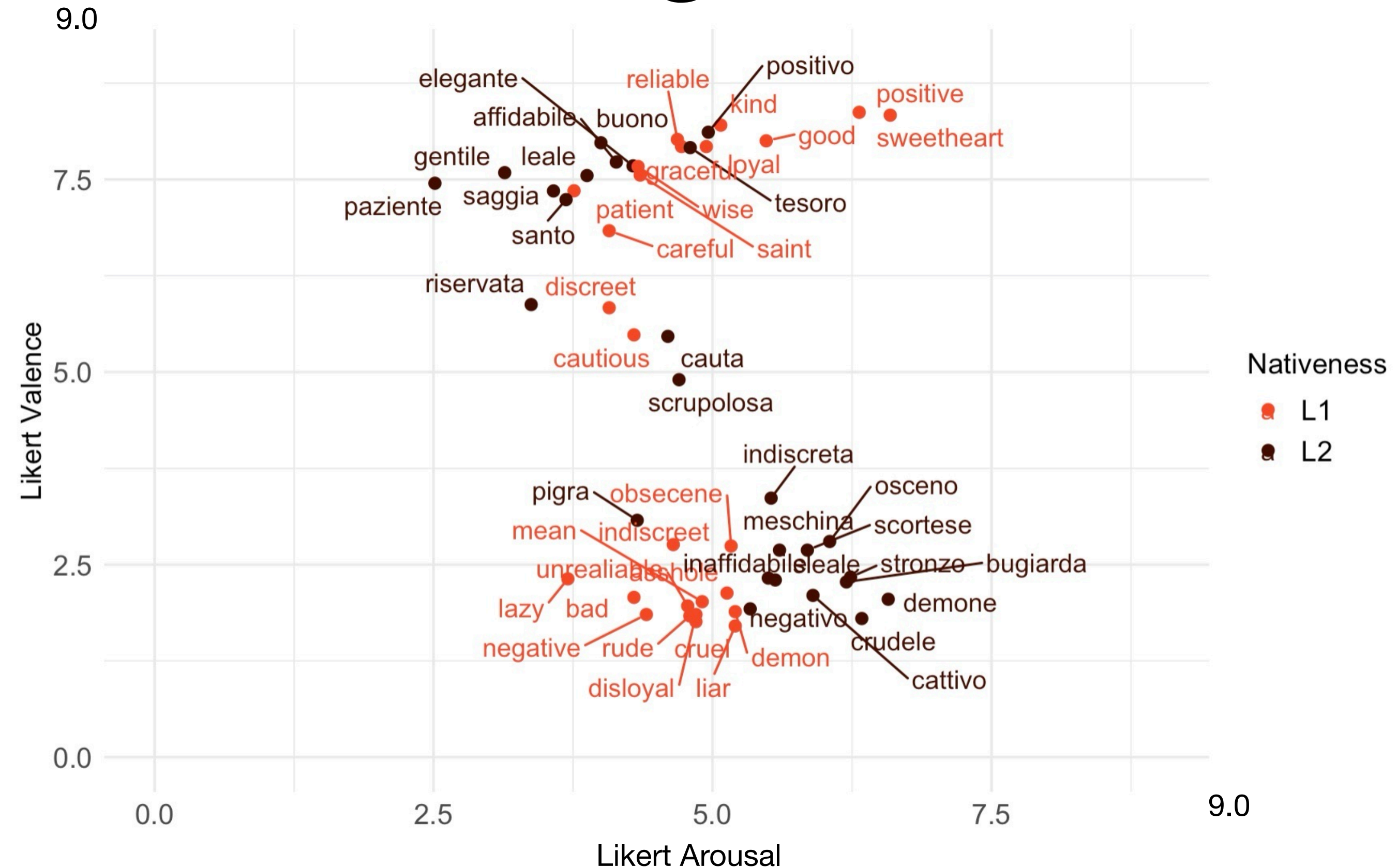
English	Italian
reliable	affidabile
unreliable	inaffidabile
liar	bugiarda
obscene	oscena
rude	scortese
lazy	pigra
mean	meschina
cruel	crudele
disloyal	sleale
kind	gentile

English	Italian
graceful	elegante
wise	saggia
careful	scrupolosa
cautious	cauta
discreet	riservata
indiscreet	indiscreta
loyal	leale
patient	paziente
sweetheart	tesoro
asshole	stronza

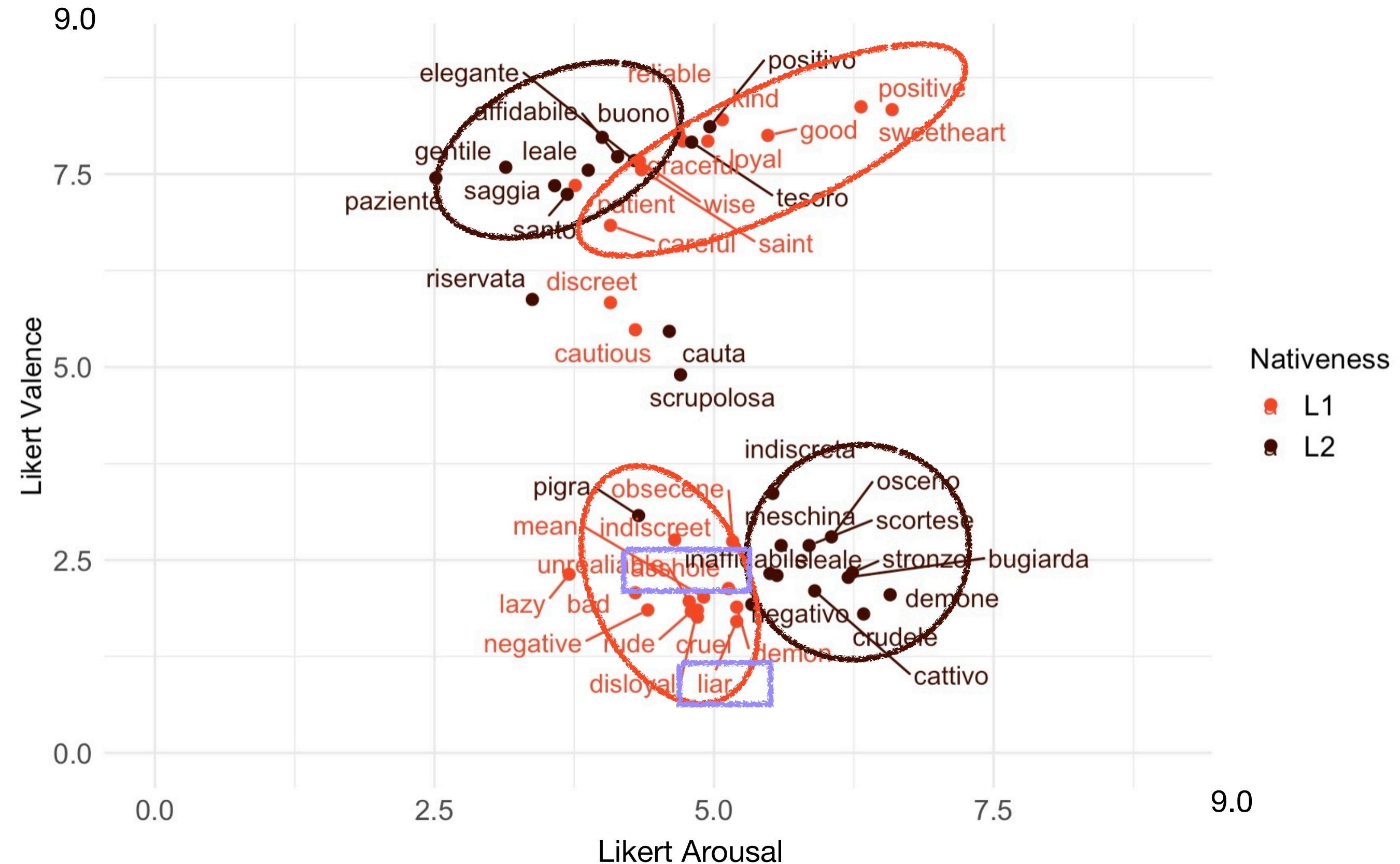
S1: L1 Italian-L2 English



S2: L1 English-L2 Italian



S2: L1 English-L2 Italian

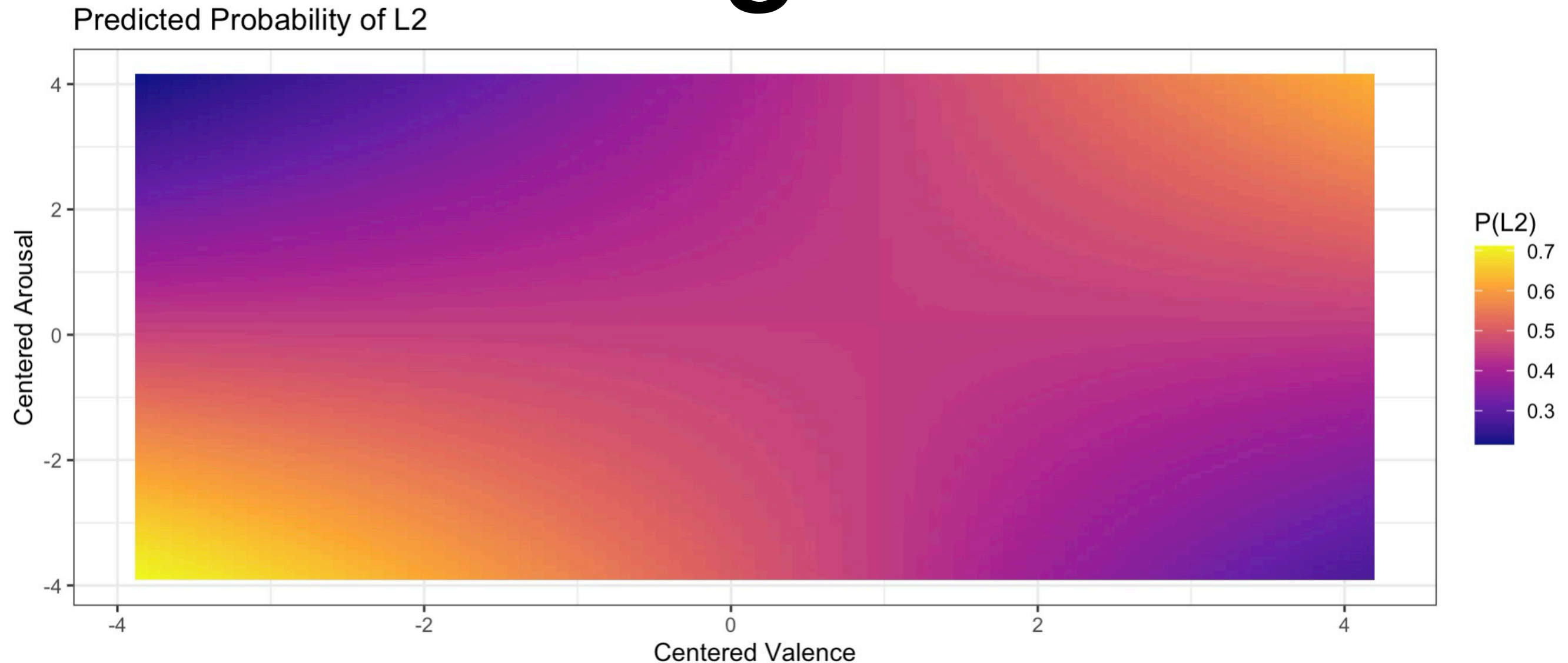


Evidence for Attenuated Affect!

Nativeness $\sim$ Valence * Arousal

Joint interaction of valence and arousal

S2: L1 English-L2 Italian



Valence alone not sufficient

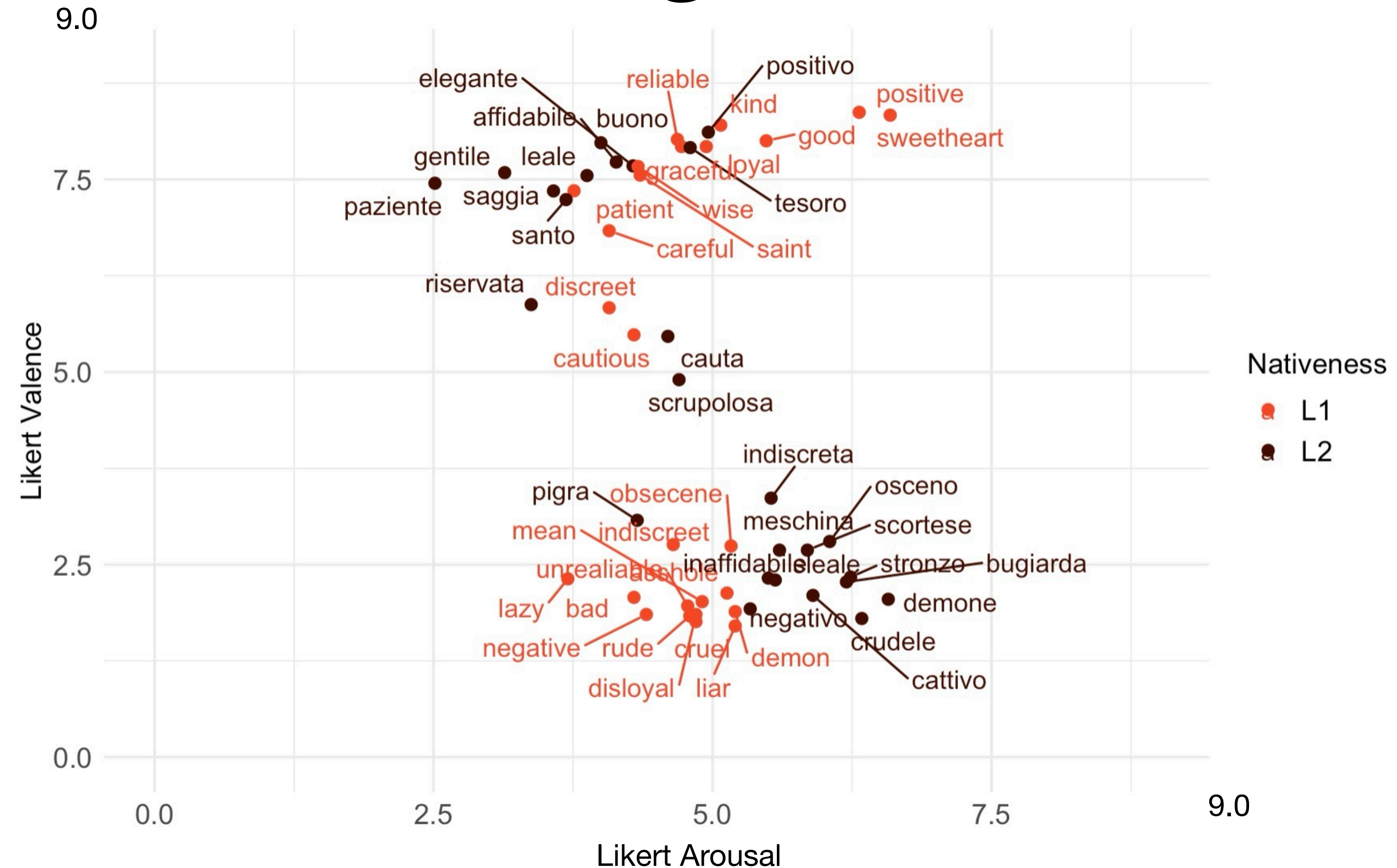
Symmetrical V-A trade-off:

- When V or A is low, the other predicts Nativeness
- At high V or A, the effect decreases

L2 has more **extreme** values:
deviation from the group mean
stronger for valence than arousal

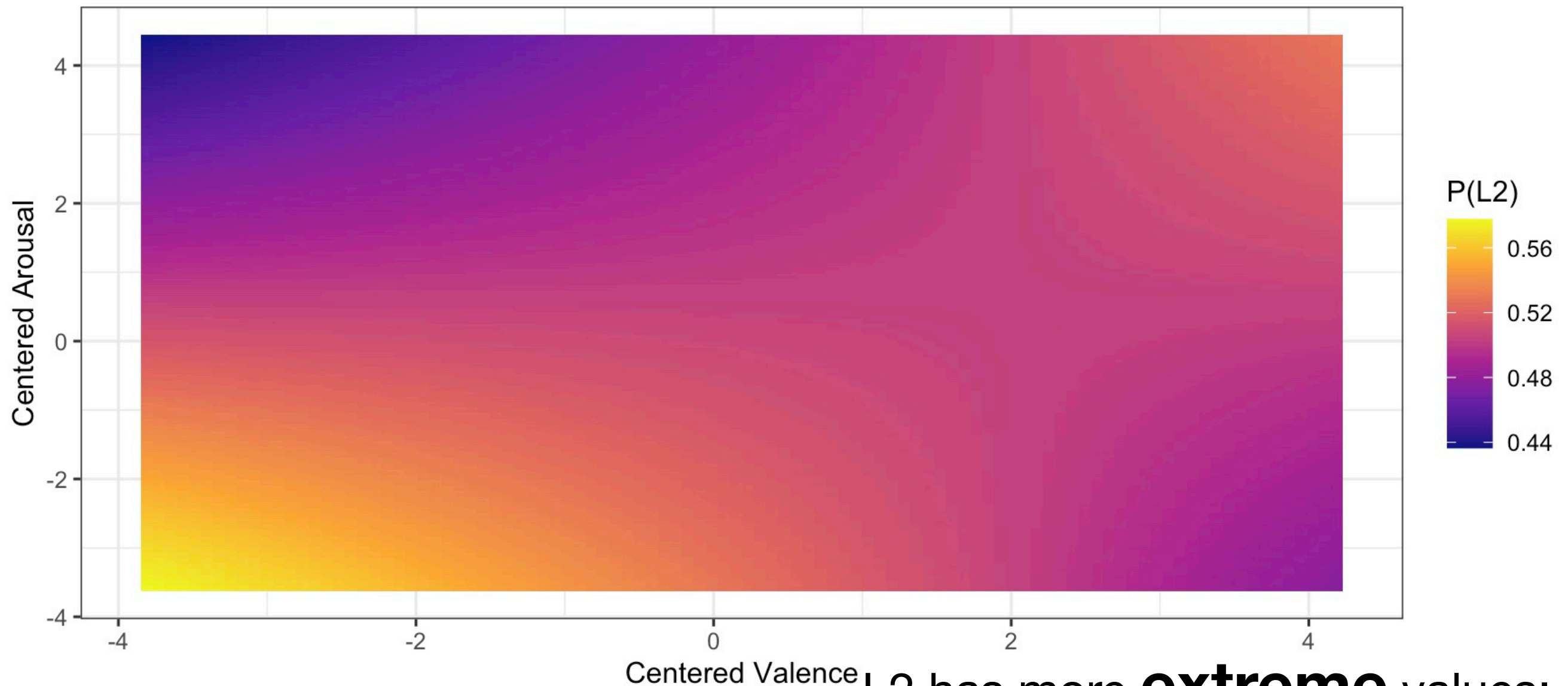
L2 has more **variability**:
Greater dispersal of values

S2: L1 English-L2 Italian



S1: L1 Italian-L2 English

Predicted Probability of L2

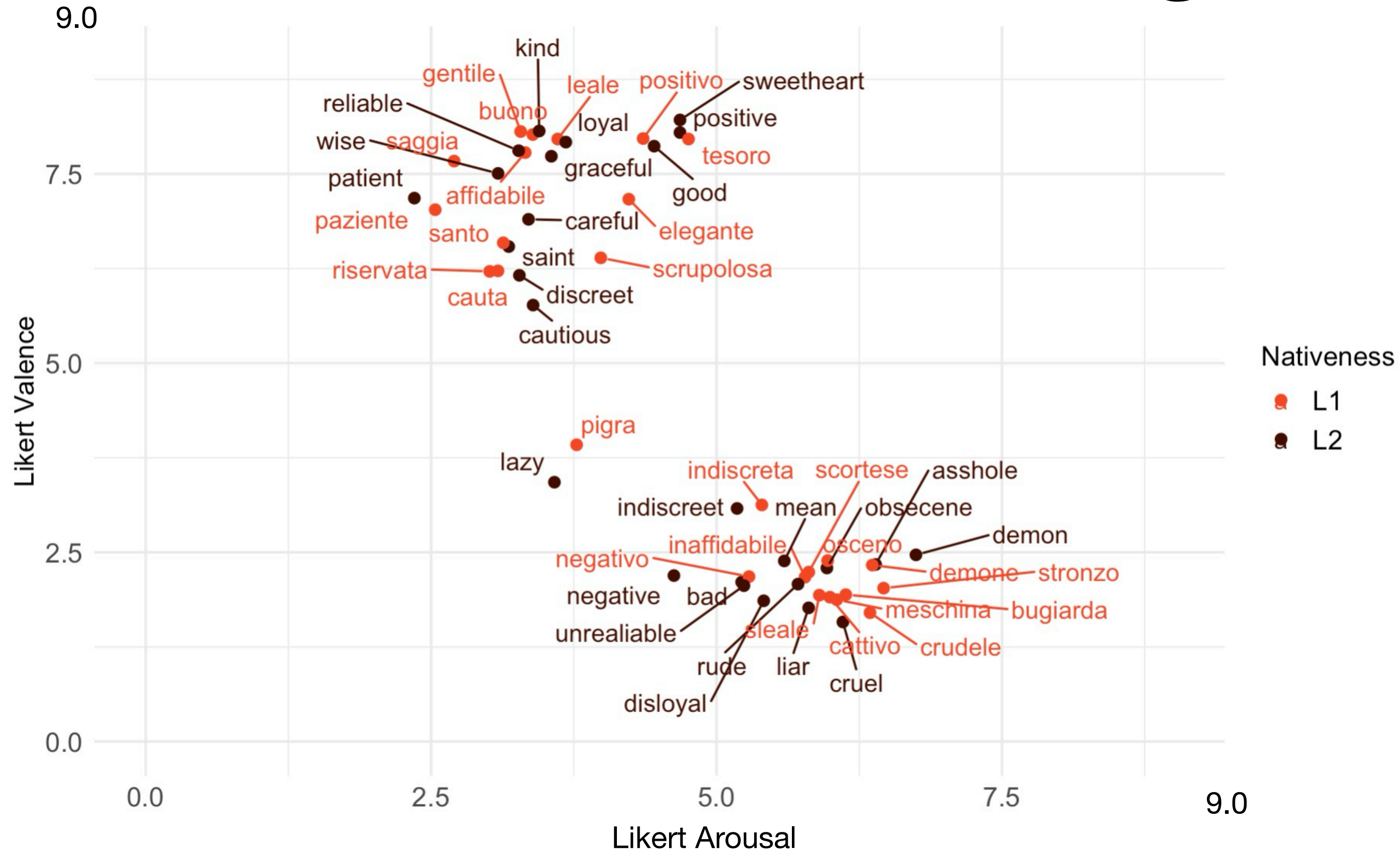


Low valence+high arousal you can predict L1, but goes away with high valence

L2 has more **extreme** values: deviation from the group mean stronger for valence than arousal

L2 has more **variability**: Greater dispersal of values

S1: L1 Italian-L2 English



Next Steps

1. Recover LEAP-Q data from Exp 1

- Need additional ethics approval (GDPR - linking)

2. Manipulating the syntactic position of the pejorative (e.g., “that asshole Luigi” vs. “Luigi is an asshole”)

3. Extend to other terms (“mixed expressives” McCready; “hybrid evaluatives”, Ceperallo & Stojanovic 2016; “value-associated terms” Willemsen & Reuter)

4. Different Language Groups

Summary

Do we replicate the contextual constraint asymmetry for negative expressives? **Yes**

- neutral < supporting ? **Yes**
- target-oriented > agent-oriented? **Yes**

Does valence impact acceptability judgements? **It's complicated**

Is there a valence asymmetry? **Yes**

Does language nativeness (L1 vs. L2):

- interact with context? **No?**
- interact with valence? **Yes-ish**
- change based on lexical category? **No differences (so far)**

What about the ratings? **Potential L1-L2 differences in the mapping of valence and arousal in the affective space**



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Any questions?

